Missing the Bus

A Look at Rural and Suburban School Bus Travel

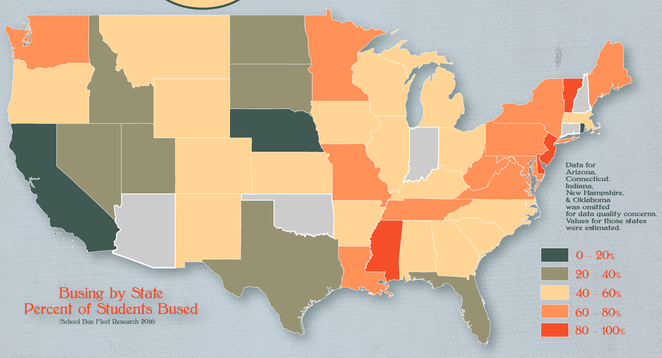
By Seth Frame

School busing by the numbers

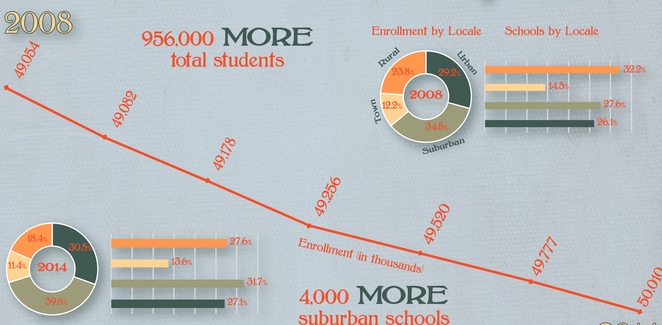
36 Each full sized school bus takes the place of 36 cars on the road

70x A student is 70 times more likely to get to school safely on a school bus than with private transportation

50% Half of the students in the United States ride a school bus to school



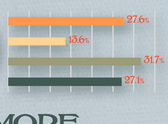
Busing by State
Percent of Students Bused
(School Bus Fleet Research 2016)



956,000 **MORE** total students

Enrollment by Locale

Schools by Locale



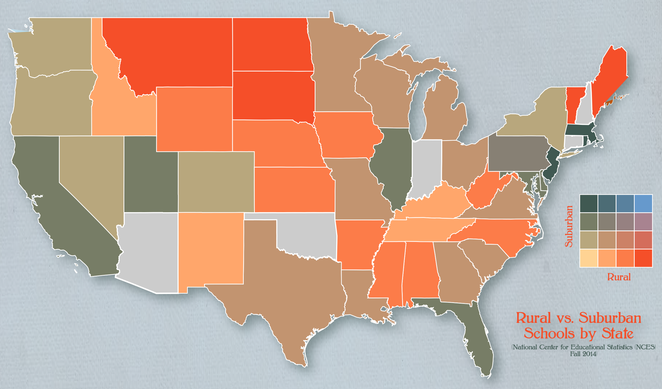
4,000 **MORE** suburban schools

2,834,000 **MORE** suburban students

4,500 **LESS** rural schools

2,471,000 **LESS** rural students

School consolidation closes rural schools and sends those students to suburban schools



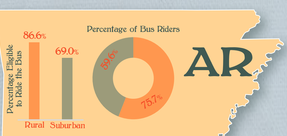
Rural vs. Suburban Schools by State
National Center for Educational Statistics (NCES) Fall 2014

A Five State Comparison

Howley et al. 2001

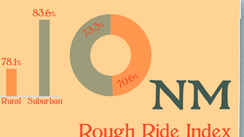
Rough Ride Index

Combination of three physical variables:
Percentage of miles over...
- hilly terrain
- mountainous terrain
- unpaved minor roads



AR

Rough Ride Index
Rural Suburban
90.6 56.7

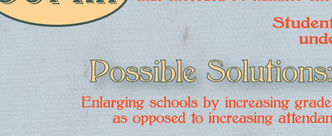


NM

Rough Ride Index
Rural Suburban
73.4 28.6

Rough Ride Index
Rural Suburban
47.7 27.6

GA



PA

Rough Ride Index
Rural Suburban
80.7 49.8

WA

Rough Ride Index
Rural Suburban
60.9 34.6

30Min All five states contained rural bus routes that exceeded 30 minutes one-way

Students are experienceing longer bus rides under less than idea conditions

Possible Solutions:

Enlarging schools by increasing grade span as opposed to increasing attendance area

A return to sustainablbe rural schools in order to limit time spent on the bus

Increased spending to improve quality of bus ride, e.g. more bus supervisors or improved infrastructure.

Howley, Craig B, Aimee A. Howley, & Steven Shamblen
2001 Riding the School Bus: A Comparison of the Rural and Suburban Experience in Five States. *Journal of Research in Rural Education* 17(1): 41-63.